Gravity and drag

Gravity pulls the parachute down. Moving air pushes back with air resistance, or drag, slowing the fall without stopping gravity.

Wide meets air

The flat filter and crumpled filter weigh the same. The wide shape meets more air, makes more drag, and falls more slowly.

Change the weight

With the same canopy and strings, two paperclips add weight. In air, that parachute usually reaches the floor sooner.

A fair test

Change one thing at a time, keep the others equal, and measure several drops. Repeating helps a result become more trustworthy.

A steadier fall

A tiny hole at the canopy top lets some air through. The flow can become more even, so the parachute wobbles less.

The same big idea

Human and space-lander parachutes use wide canopies too. Gravity pulls down while drag pushes against motion and slows the descent.

Make a little book

1 Fold it into 8 boxes. Open it flat.

2 Fold short end to short end. Cut the thick line. Open it.

3 Fold the long way, pictures out. Push the ends in.

4 Fold into a book. Page 1 goes on the front!

WONDER DAILY

A Coffee Filter Parachute